

SECTION 1

Establishing Yourself as a Leader

1

When Your Employees Have More Experience Than You

by Jodi Glickman

Becoming a manager can feel intimidating. Suddenly, you're in charge of not only your success, but also the growth and achievements of your team.

And if you're in the early stages of your career, this transition can be even more difficult. You may still be trying to figure out who you are and what you want. And yet, it's now your responsibility to bring out the best in others and inspire them to do great work.

While there are plenty of challenges that come along with taking on a management position early in your career, among your first will probably be managing and leading people who have more years of experience than you. How do you engender their trust, respect, and admiration?

Check Your Insecurities

You may not have as many years of experience as some of your direct reports, but that doesn't mean you don't deserve your leadership position.

If you find yourself worrying about not being taken seriously or respected by your employees, take a step back. Try looking for real-world evidence that supports your thoughts. Then, look for evidence that suggests the opposite.

Ask yourself: Would I have been promoted into this role if my supervisor, and the company, thought I was incompetent? Probably not. You may also find that your colleagues don't actually attribute competence or high performance to years of experience.

No matter what you discover, remind yourself of this often: You belong in the seat you are occupying.

Get Everyone on the Same Page

People get picked to be managers because of their talents and people skills. This could be your ability to make sound decisions, bring different people together, influence others, and stay calm during tough moments.

When you start out, engage with your direct reports in one-on-ones. Talk about your vision and goals for the team. Remember that they come with experience, and their experience can help you refine your ideas. Leave space for two-way dialogue and stay open to feedback.

Be Confident Enough to Be Vulnerable

If you are feeling unsure or insecure while leading, your team will be able to read that energy and may become unsure of your leadership, too. That's why it's important to practice confidence when speaking to them: Make eye contact, use gestures to accentuate your point, stand or sit up straight, and maintain strong body language. Practicing your delivery method will help you speak with conviction, be clear about your intentions, and show up as the leader you aspire to be.

At the same time, don't be afraid to be vulnerable and relate to your team during challenging projects or conversations. You're not expected to walk in on day one and be an expert. You are, however, expected to be 100% honest—about the challenges your team is facing, the strategies you are contemplating, and your willingness to listen and learn from those around you.

When you share your ideas, leave room for your team to (honestly) reflect on them. Let them know that you value their opinions and experiences. You could say, "This is what I had in mind, and here's why.... What do you think? Do you agree? Disagree? Is there anything we're missing here? I'd love to have your thoughts and feedback."

Especially when it comes to more experienced direct reports who may have worked at the organization longer than you have, solicit their opinions on what has worked in the past, what their current working style is, and where things are due for change. Ask how you can best support them. Say, "I know we started this new workflow last month. I wanted to know how you feel about it and take some time to review it."

When you do that, be receptive to their ideas and views. Be transparent about your desire to establish a true partnership. Your goal should be to bring out the best in one another.

Be Generous

Leaders who are generous—with their time, energy, and resources, with sharing credit and giving meaningful feedback—are the ones who earn respect and admiration from their teams. Generosity at its most basic is this: Walking in every day and asking yourself, "How can I make my teams' lives better or easier?" "What can I do to help them do their jobs successfully?" "How can I be an advocate for their ideas or support their initiatives?" "How can I showcase what they do right and have their back when things go wrong?"

Recognize that your employees may be at a different life stage than you. Spend time to learn more about them. Get a deeper sense of any barriers they may be facing and how you can try to remove them or, at the very least, be creative in coming up with workarounds or ways to collaborate. For instance, you may find that one employee has to homeschool their child during work hours. What can you do to support them and make their lives a little easier?

Being empathetic is critical to being a good leader. Do your best to accommodate different needs.

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Regardless of your years of experience, you have what it takes to be a successful manager and leader. Rely on your transferable skills, show strength and humility, and demonstrate your willingness to learn alongside your team.

QUICK RECAP

Becoming a manager comes with many challenges, including having to manage people with more experience than you. How do you move forward?

- **Check your insecurities.** Remind yourself of this often: You belong in the seat you are occupying.
 - **Get everyone on the same page.** Talk to your direct reports about your vision and goals for the team and leave space for two-way dialogue.
 - **Be confident enough to be vulnerable.** Practice confidence when speaking to your team, but don't be afraid to show vulnerability during challenging conversations.
 - **Be generous.** Being empathetic is critical to being a good leader. Do your best to accommodate different needs.
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Adapted from "When You're Younger Than the People You Manage," on hbr.org, December 24, 2020.

How can you ensure you'll be taken seriously as a manager? Listen to this podcast:



2

How to Determine Your Work Style as a Manager

by Claire Hughes Johnson

When I was an executive at Google, I worked with a talented manager who had one big flaw: He told his team *everything*.

Eli (name has been changed to preserve anonymity) often broke company news to his team before anyone else had a chance to share it, or worried his team members by telling them how stressed he was about, say, a reorganization of our division. When I talked to him about it, Eli agreed that this was a problem. But he would not change his behavior.

Soon after one of these conversations, Eli and I took part in a training session in which we each reflected on the values that were most important to us. I'll never forget the story Eli told. When he was seven or eight, Eli's mom was diagnosed with breast cancer. Nobody told Eli what was happening—his family tried to pretend everything was OK. Eventually, Eli's mother was hospitalized, and he wasn't allowed to visit her. One day, Eli's stepfather picked him up from school and took him out to his favorite diner. Over pancakes, Eli learned his mother had died.

Eli's value was transparency.

Both Eli and I came away from that exercise changed. I learned that when you're dealing with a difficult behavior—in yourself or in others—there's often a deeper root cause. Eli gained a stronger awareness of why he communicated the way he did.

This episode underscored a core principle I've emphasized throughout my career: Self-awareness in the workplace is always a superpower, but when you're a manager, it's even more important. You need to understand your work style—your strengths and weaknesses—in order to do your best work and help other people do theirs.

Here, I'll share two exercises you can use to develop self-awareness and communicate your work style and values to your teams.

Identify Your Work Style

Throughout my career, and in studying many personality and work-style assessments, I've found that two main criteria often determine people's work styles: (1) whether they're more introverted or extroverted; and (2) whether they're more task-oriented or people-oriented.

To determine whether you're more introverted or extroverted, ask yourself:

- Do I talk to think or think to talk?
- Do I do my best work with others or by myself?
- Do meetings and group work make me feel more energized or depleted?

I don't consider myself a heavy extrovert, for example, but I do need to talk out my ideas to arrive at the best answers. If you're more extroverted, you may find that talking through a challenge with a colleague or collaboratively problem-solving with your team will help you come to a more thought-out conclusion. If you're more introverted, you may find it more productive to think through plans or solutions independently before sharing them with a wider group for feedback.

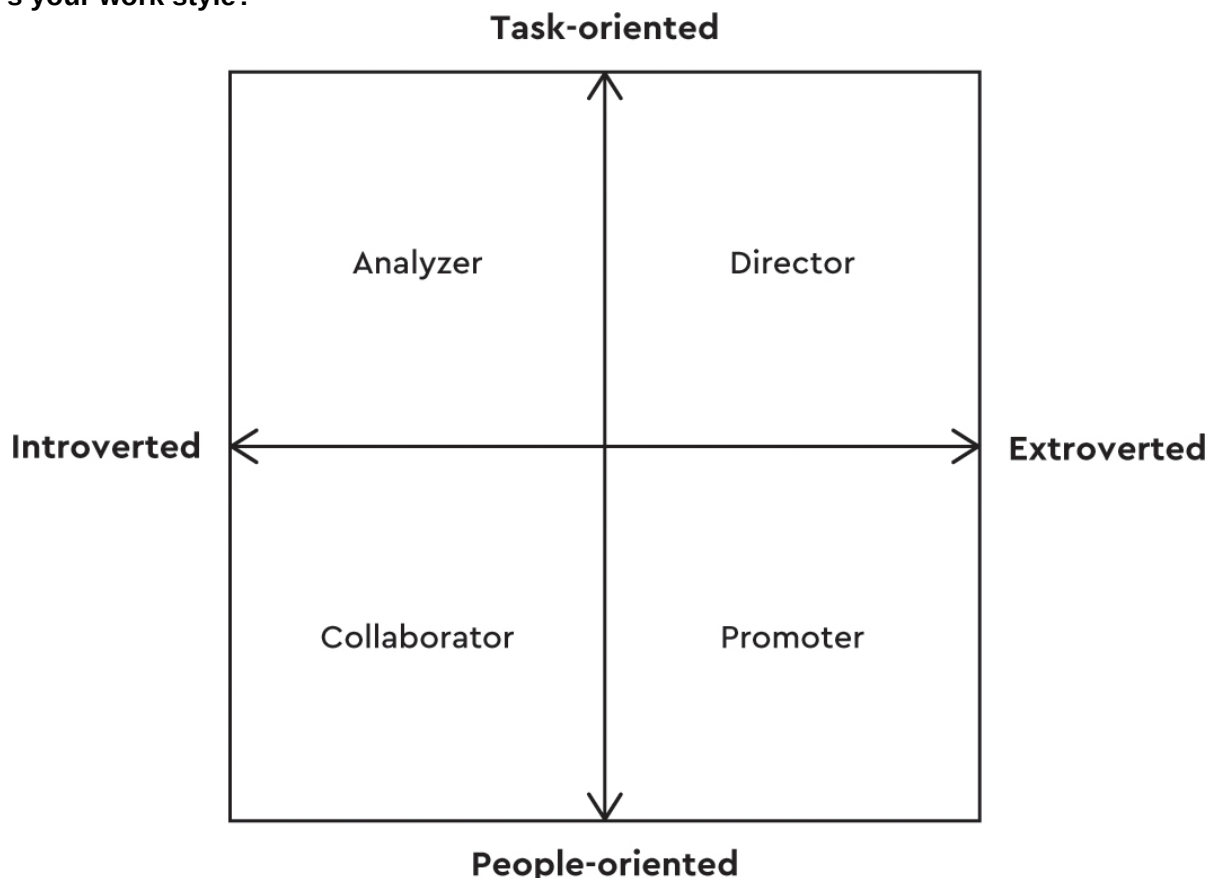
To determine whether you're more task-oriented or people-oriented, consider:

- Am I more likely to focus on the work itself or on the people doing it?
- Do I tend to place more value on doing things quickly and efficiently or on bringing people along in the process and generating consensus for the path forward?
- When faced with a problem, am I more likely to start thinking about solutions or gathering perspectives on the situation from others?

Task-oriented people tend to pay more attention to the most efficient way to get things done and less on generating buy-in around the right approach. Folks who are more people-oriented tend to build consensus around the path forward, but they may lose sight of completing the task efficiently in the interest of bringing people along.

FIGURE 2-1

What's your work style?



Source: Adapted from Claire Hughes Johnson, *Scaling People: Tactics for Management and Company Building* (San Francisco: Stripe Press, 2023).

Where you fall on the axes in [figure 2-1](#) will help you determine which of four work styles you fall into. I call them the analyzer, the director, the collaborator, and the promoter.

- **Analyzers** make rigorous, deliberate, and data-driven decisions. They're great at coming to the right answer, but they may have trouble acting without data. They may not be as skilled at collaborating, building processes, or seeking consensus.
- **Directors** are opinionated and great at establishing a vision. They have a bias toward action because they care about getting to the right outcomes quickly, but that means they often dictate exactly what needs to be done, which can disempower others, or do the work themselves without bringing others along.

- *Collaborators* care a lot about stakeholders or customers, whether that's an internal customer (like another team) or an external one. They're great at building systems and processes, but they may overcomplicate those systems because they don't want to leave anyone out.
- *Promoters* tend to have a lot of ideas. They're great at building relationships, and they're able to articulate an inspiring narrative that others want to get behind. But they're less concerned with details or administration, so they're often great starters but not always finishers.

Knowing your work style—and, ideally, that of your direct reports—will help you be a more effective and empathetic manager. In terms of your team, you can use the work-style assessment to ensure it's well-rounded, representing a mix of work-style preferences and strengths. For yourself, it will help you be mindful of your weaker points and when they're likely to show up, allowing you to prepare a plan for how you'll address them.

For example, as a director, I know that when faced with a problem or an urgent situation, I tend to be too quick to jump to action. Instead, I try to follow this rule in team settings: Before diving into solutions, I ask a question first. This keeps me from moving too quickly and helps my team work on their own problem-solving skills.

Articulate Your Values

The next step is to identify the values that motivate you. The combination of your work style and values guides how you lead and collaborate with others. Try this exercise:

1. Imagine yourself late in life, reflecting on your career. In the end, what was most important to you?
2. Write down 10 values that represent your ideal of that fulfilled life. (Some examples might be accomplishment, balance, community, joy, impact, and learning.)
3. Narrow down the list to five values, then three.
4. Write down activities that embody each value. If your value is *excellence*, for example, an activity might be that you never deliver a project unless it's nearly perfect.
5. Consider the positive outcomes of those values as well as the trade-offs. Valuing excellence, for instance, might also mean you push your team to deliver great work, but often set unrealistic expectations or unattainable deadlines.

Think about the values you identified. How do they intersect with your work style? Recognizing this can help you uncover and address your unconscious biases, lean into your strengths, and better communicate both of them with others.

For example, if you value community and are a collaborator, you may go the extra mile to connect with and create psychological safety for your team. But perhaps through this exercise, you noticed that you don't give people enough autonomy. Or maybe you value impact and are a director. You may be excellent at driving results, but less experienced at slowing down and teaching your direct reports the skills they need to learn on their own.

Communicate Your Work Style and Values

Be open with your direct reports about your work style and the values that drive you so they can understand how best to work with you and provide feedback on the unconscious biases your values inevitably create. You can even create a "Working with Me" document that clearly outlines how you like to collaborate, your work style, your communication preferences, the areas you're working on, and more. Better yet, have your team members walk through the same exercise as a group, with a greater focus on their communication preferences and work habits. Then, adjust to meet each other in the middle and watch how quickly your collaboration improves.

The values exercise Eli and I did was a master class in self- and mutual awareness. It became clear that Eli wanted to communicate with his team in a more productive way, but withholding information felt like a betrayal of his commitment to transparency. Understanding this, we were able to find a path forward: Eli would consult his

peers and manager before sharing critical decisions with his team, and he would be more measured in how he communicated those decisions. But we would also commit to trustworthy and clear communication as part of every plan we made. He and his team were stronger for it, as was our entire organization.

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Self-awareness is a skill that will serve you throughout your career, and one that you should continue to develop and nurture over time. It can be the key trait that differentiates you from others early on, and it will help you steer toward work that makes the most of what you have to offer—now and in the years ahead of you.

QUICK RECAP

It's important to understand your work style as a manager so you can do your best work and help other people do theirs.

- Are you introverted or extroverted? More task-oriented or people-oriented? Depending on how you identify, you're either an analyzer, a director, a collaborator, or a promoter.
 - What are the values that motivate you? The combination of your work style and values guides how you lead and collaborate with others.
 - Once you've identified your work style and values, discuss them with your direct reports so they can understand how best to work with you.
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Adapted from "How to Determine Your Work Style as a New Manager," on hbr.org, March 3, 2023.

3

Lessons from a First-Time, First-Generation Manager

by Kela Lester

One of the many lessons Black parents instill in their children is that in order to succeed, we have to be twice as good as our peers: twice as smart, twice as talented. This advice is ingrained in everything from literature to pop culture. Now, there's data to back it up: Despite being among the most educated and productive, Black workers and other workers from marginalized communities are overrepresented in low-wage, entry-level jobs and underrepresented in senior leadership and executive roles.¹

While there's extensive research on the glass ceiling and how to break it, there's less talk about its close relative, the "concrete wall"—a set of obstacles that keep Black, Indigenous, and people of color (BIPOC) professionals, especially women, from securing high-level positions.

The concrete wall, as described by Ella L. J. Bell Smith, a professor of management sciences at the Tuck School of Business, "limits your capacity to learn and understand what's [happening] on the other side—the culture, the behavior, the expectations, the rules. If you don't know what's on the other side, and nobody's telling you what the rules are—or if somebody keeps changing the rules without your knowing it—you can't play the game."²

So, what happens when you finally chip away at the wall and move into a managerial position for the first time? What should you do if you're the first person in your family to navigate this new opportunity?

Here are three baseline lessons I've learned in my few years as a first-time and first-generation manager.

Start Within

Confidence is a cornerstone of leadership. Proposing a new idea? You need to display your expertise to get stakeholder buy-in. Hosting a meeting? People won't engage with you unless they aspire to be a part of something larger. Setting expectations and giving feedback? No one listens to someone who isn't sure of themselves. The list goes on.

Whenever you feel unsure of yourself as a new leader, take a moment to remember the unique upbringing and point of view that got you to where you are today. When I first began my role as a manager, I thought that the key to success was code-switching—changing my appearance, behavior, or speech to fit in with the majority group. It wasn't until I gained the confidence to share and celebrate my personality that I realized my power. Tapping into my resilience, adaptability, and resourcefulness successfully positioned me to contribute to company culture, confront racial bias, and break unrealistic expectations. Once I was comfortable being myself, I not only pursued opportunities that were right for the real me, but could also bring another perception to ideas that others overlooked.

Whatever your own story may be, use your strengths to build a foundation of confidence. Then, add to it. One way you can do this is by emulating the leadership styles of mentors or managers you admire. Observe them, ask for their advice, and take on the traits that resonate with you most. These may be emotional intelligence, humility, kindness, creativity, integrity, courage, and even the ability to persuade others, depending on your approach. Likewise, leave behind the traits that don't feel right, or that were more hurtful than helpful to you as a direct report.

Last, celebrate your wins. In my first leadership role, I tracked mine monthly in a draft email and pulled it up whenever I could use the extra pat on the back. The more you practice self-confidence in small ways, the more comfortable you'll become. If you want a unified team to venture with you into the unknown, it all starts from within.

Step Back from the Trees to See the Forest

Your team members likely seek the same autonomy and authority that you've achieved in moving beyond the concrete wall, which leads me to my next point. Get comfortable relinquishing control of the details and ask for help when you need it. This may be tough if you're used to doing it all.

Earlier in your career, it may have made sense to know every moving part of a project. While it can be hard to let go and stop exercising the technical skills that made you a great candidate in the first place, being a manager requires a new level of support—more listening and guiding others than doing.

When assigning projects to your direct reports, avoid the urge to micromanage. Give them a goal, a deadline, and clear expectations. Then let them figure out how to achieve that goal, reach that deadline, and meet those expectations. This will free up space for you to observe. Pay attention to their strengths, challenge areas, and motivations, and provide them with the support they need to succeed. In doing so, you can delegate meaningful projects to each person while also creating a culture of continuous feedback.

To pull your focus away from the “how,” it also helps to think about ways you can make the team work better as a collective. For instance, instead of taking the reins when someone is falling behind, use your energy to troubleshoot and improve workflows. Plan quarterly goals for each person and the team as a whole in advance. Create a predictable communication cadence, including regular check-ins and guardrails for feedback.

Now that you've finally arrived in a new position, this is your chance to make an impact on the bigger picture and allow your team members to grow in their own way.

Cultivate a Community

Companies ramping up their diversity, equity, and inclusion efforts are keen on creating a sense of belonging—an employee's perception of acceptance within a given group. As a new leader, try creating a community instead.

Stanford University has a nice explanation of the difference:

Although “belonging” includes an individual's sense of connection to and personal identification with the whole, “community” embraces an individual's participation and belief in something larger than themselves. Creating and supporting a thriving community involves both collectively establishing a group's values and norms and respecting the importance and responsibility of every individual in contributing to a shared vision and the daily life of that common good.³

Building rapport goes beyond knowing your teammates' professional goals. It's about creating a psychologically safe environment. Schedule weekly one-on-ones with each of your direct reports and use a part of this time to better understand how their personal lives affect how they show up to work. The advice here is not to spend half an hour discussing your social life but, rather, to check in with people on both a professional and a personal level. Make them feel seen, appreciated, and heard as a human being, not just a worker.

For instance, how many children does a person have? How is their work-life balance? What cultural holidays do they need space to honor or celebrate? Do they feel that their work has value? Do they understand how their tasks are contributing to the larger organization? Even questions about what Netflix series they'd recommend or what books they're currently reading can show people that you care about their tastes and interests, and help to build an inclusive space.

In a hybrid work environment where Slack or Microsoft Teams are the new watercoolers, tapping into the human side of the business—and sending a meme or two—clears the way for innovation with working relationships centered on understanding and respect.

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My advice above all: Give yourself grace. Even as the diversity industry continues to grow, underrepresented talent remains stuck in the middle, with fewer growth opportunities or senior executive pathways. In breaking the concrete wall, you’ve made it through an immense systemic challenge passed down from the generations before us.

QUICK RECAP

What should you do when you step into a managerial position for the first time? Here are three lessons from a first-time, first-generation manager:

- Confidence is a cornerstone of leadership. Whenever you feel unsure of yourself as a new leader, take a moment to remember your unique skills and wins.
 - Get comfortable relinquishing control of the details and ask for help when you need it. Listen and guide others, rather than taking the reins yourself.
 - Create a community with your team by building rapport and a psychologically safe environment for all. Get to know your reports on a professional and a personal level.
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Adapted from “Leading as a First-Time, First-Generation Manager,” on hbr.org, October 21, 2021.